All About Al

By Cherie Vogelstein

GIL, very handsome and cool, sits with his back to us in an empty coffee shop, reads the sports section. LENNY, downtrodden and uncool, enters in raincoat and galoshes, furtively looks around, spots GIL, quickly looks away, orders coffee. Nonchalantly, LENNY takes cup and saunters by GIL's table. Suddenly, he stops, pretends to notice GIL for first time. Their initial conversation should be slightly awkward: the way it is when casual friends meet after not speaking for awhile: full of sound and excitement, signifying nothing.

LENNY: Gil! *[Practically spills cup.]*

GIL: *[Looks up, friendly.]* Hey... Lenny!

LENNY: What a surprise, what a coincidence!

GIL: Yehah - how ya doin', buddy?

LENNY: How are you? You look great!

GIL: Yeah? Well I'm doin' okay, you know, hangin' in there. *[Awkward pause, then with some concern.]* . . . how uh . . . how are YOU doin', Len?

LENNY: *[Jovially.]* Me? Well, I'm fine . . . alright, you know . . . not so good - *[Totally serious.]* - suicidal - I'm suicidal, Gil.

GIL: *[Sympathetic.]* Yeah, heard about you and Cindy. I'm sorry, man, we shoulda called.

LENNY: No, no I should've called you guys . . . it's just I've been so preoccupied, you know, with death, I haven't had any time. *[Cheery.]* So how's Allison?

GIL: Allison? She's real good . . . yeah, she should be comin' here

LENNY: *[Excited.]* Really?!

GIL: Yeah.

LENNY: Here? Really? *[GIL nods.]* That's great, that is so great!

GIL: *[Puzzled by LENNY's enthusiasm.]* Yeah . . . any minute.

LENNY: *[Elated.]* I - I can't wait to see her, I mean what good luck . . . that is so fantastic, just terrific . . . incredible really. . .

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GIL: *[Beat.]* You're not gettin' out much, are ya, Len?

LENNY: *[Instantly sad, sits, cradles his head.]* It's hopeless, Gil. I'm miserable, a wreck; all alone during allergy season with my hair falling out and my gums big and bleeding - may I join you?

GIL: *[Looks around uncomfortably.]* Uh

LENNY: - I mean you don't know how lucky you are - wow to have a woman like Allison, kind, darling, beautiful Al

GIL: - I think we're breakin' up.

LENNY: *[Shocked.]* What?

GIL: *[Beat.]* Yeah.

LENNY: *[Devastated beat.]* No.

GIL: Yeah.

LENNY: *[2 Beats.]* No.

GIL: *[Annoyed.]* LENNY!

INTRODUCTION

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LENNY: I'm sorry but I . . . can't believe it . . . I mean I just can't believe it - you and Allison, Allison and you . . . you're like Romeo and Juliet. . . Antony and Cleopatra . . . Lawrence Olivier and Danny Kaye

GIL: Well, listen . . . I'm just tellin' ya cuz maybe, you know, it's not such a good idea for you to be around when I tell her

LENNY: Why, Gil? I'll be very quiet

GIL: Right but uh . . . even though it's a cafe deal and I'm hopin' she'll keep the cryin' down to a minimum . . . I'll tell ya, Len, things might get pretty wacky - I mean, it's not easy breakin' a girl's heart. . . ya know?

LENNY: No . . . I don't know. . . I've dreamt about it ... *[Assumes the mannerisms of a girl]*

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GIL: Yeah, well so anyway. . . I think that's what I'm gonna do. *[Pause.]* Oh! *[Laughs.]* No offense, Len but you make a real ugly girl.

LENNY: *[Sticking to his role, falsetto.]* Did you want to speak to me about something?

GIL: O.K., O.K. yeah . . . *[Serious.]* . . . I did . . . listen, Al, I haveta tell you something

LENNY: *[Coquettishly.]* I love you, Gilly

GIL: Yeah, I love you too. It's over. We have to break up.

LENNY: What?! Why?!

GIL: Why? *[Thinks.]* Honestly? Because . . . I have a brain tumor

LENNY: *[Falsetto]* Oh my God! You do?

GIL: No, no, no - seriously? We have to break up because . . . I'm not good enough for you, Al, I think you deserve better

LENNY: *[Falsetto.]* I do but I don't want better, I want you, YOU *[Almost to himself]* - moronic, greasy

GIL: *[Oblivious.]* Yeah, but the thing is . . . I don't think I can measure up to this . . . this IMAGE you have of me, ya know? I mean, sure we might be good today, we might be good tomorrow but ultimately, I don't have what it takes to fulfill a woman like you. And one day, one day I'm gonna look into your eyes and I'm gonna see - insteada the love - I'm gonna see somethin' else - I'm gonna see all the respect drained out and gone with only the hate left. And that's gonna break my heart, Al- *[Sobs.]*

LENNY: *[As himself]* Wow. Is that true?

GIL: No but it sounded good, right? *[Beat.]* I mean, you can't tell her the real stuff. . . Well it's no big deal really, just this thing she does sometimes when . . . when we're lyin' there . . . ya know, in bed . . . and I'll be gettin' all comfortable, I'll be startin' to doze off - and allofa sudden, outta nowhere, I'll feel this leg swingin' over on top of me, right over my body while I'm tryin' to sleep.

LENNY: Is it her leg?

GIL: Of course, it's her leg that's not the point - the point is while I'm tryin' to sleep, I don't need some weight pinnin' me down to the mattress, you know what I mean?

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LENNY: Cindy bought a bunk bed when I moved in

GIL: I mean, I'm not sayin' I don't appreciate Al's affection - I'm not saying that at all - but there's a time and a place and [when I'm trying to sleep] . . . I do NOT like to be touched, ya know?

LENNY: Cindy said [all touching] should be kept to a minimum.

GIL: Listen, Len, can I just say? - she did you the biggest favor in the world when she dumped you

LENNY: I know, I know. That's the one favor women always want to do for me - *[With sudden emotion.]* - which is why I'm telling you it's lonely in New York, Gil- Allison is special-

GIL: Yeah, I know she's special but . . . but . . . it's not just the leg thing, Lenny. . . it's more than that. . .

LENNY: You mean like a leg/arm kind of thing?

GIL: I mean like. . . like - *[Thinks of something.]* -like the way she's so obsessed with her weight! I mean, all she ever does is ask me about it all the time: Like I won't have seen her for a day and I'll pick her up and first thing when she opens the door, she'll say, "Hi, Gil, do I look like I gained weight?"

LENNY: So?

GIL: So I'll say - No, Al, you look great - and she'll say – are you sure? - and I'll say - positive - and she'll say - no you're lying -and I'll say - why would I lie? - to make me feel good - no, no way - yes, I see it in your eyes - no, that's my contact lens Al, ya haven't gained an ounce since the day you were born - you promise? - I swear - you'd tell me if I did - of course - you promise you would tell me? – I promise - you promise you promise - I promise, I swear, I swear on my life now give me a stake to put through my head cuz I can't take it anymore, Lenny, it drives me nuts!

LENNY: Why? *[GIL rolls his eyes in frustration.]* You mean because she's a little insecure about her figure . . . needs a little reassurance, a little positive assessment of her weight?

GIL: Yeah, but like . . . why doesn't she just invest inna scale? Ya know what I mean? Why's it havta be such a big mystery all the time?

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LENNY: Gil, Gil, YOU'RE her scale, Gil, YOU

GIL: But that's the thing - to me she looks great-so what's she so worried about?

LENNY: *[Shrugging.]* Maybe she's afraid if she got fat, you'd break up with her.

GIL: *[Softens.]* Well, yeah . . . I would - but that doesn't mean she has to like "dwell," ya know? *[Guiltily.]* I mean, come on, Len every guy wants his girlfriend to have a nice body, right?

LENNY: *[Nodding.]* Cindy gained 60 pounds while we were together.

GIL: God, I know - how'd you deal with that, man?

LENNY: I loved her for what was inside

GIL: Deep, deep inside

LENNY: *[Impassioned.]* Look, a good woman is hard to find

GIL: Cindy's not hard to find - *[Spreads his arms wide.] [Looks around, then at his watch.]* I wonder why Al's so late.

LENNY: Cindy was always late, Cindy

GIL: Cindy, Cindy, will you forget Cindy!

LENNY: It just ended last week, Gil.

GIL: Yeah, well get over it already, alright? Get over it!

LENNY: *[Repeats to himself.]* Get over it.

GIL: -what you need is somebody nice, somebody sweet, a girl who gives ya support, makes ya feel good, really LIKES you

LENNY: *[Like a kid at a toy store.]* They have that?

GIL: Yeah, yeah, ya just gotta give yourself a break, buddy, ya know what I mean? Ya gotta ... go for it, ya know? *[Beat.]* Just go for it! *[Pause.]*

LENNY: Gil?

GIL: Yeah, Len?

LENNY: When uh when Allison gets here. . .

GIL: Yeah?

LENNY: When Allison gets here . . .

GIL: *[Very calm.]* Finish the sentence, Len.

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LENNY: Can I . . . have her?

GIL: What?

LENNY: Well not "have her," "have her" is a silly expression but you know what I mean - could I ask her out - would you mind?

GIL: Would I mind? If you asked Allison out? *[Beat.]* My Allison, right? You mean Allison Kramer.

LENNY: Listen, if it's a problem

GIL: No, it's no problem

LENNY: - then I won't

GIL: Lenny. I said it's not a problem, okay?

LENNY: Okay. *[Beat, smiling broadly, happily.]* Thanks, Gilly.

GIL: Don't call me Gilly, alright? *[Beat, scowling.]* But I'm just thinkin' ...

LENNY: *[Serious.]* Uh-huh, good, O.K.

GIL: Ya know . . . what about "Cindy?"

LENNY: Oh. Well you said to forget her.

GIL: And that's it? That's all it takes - I say forget her and you're done?

LENNY: Well, Gil, I thought you gave me some very excellent advice and so I'm trying to follow up on it, is all

GIL: Yeah, well, okay . . . good. But I haveta tell ya, Len, maybe this is sicka me an' all, but it kinda does bother me, ya know? *[Annoyed and confused.]* I mean you askin' Allison out! I mean cuz like . . . here you are, and and like . . . the body's still warm, ya know what I'm sayin'?

LENNY: Yes but in a way, isn't that better? *[Smiles broadly.]* I mean, that way she won't have time to mourn over the loss of you because I'll be right there to console her

GIL: *[Getting angrier.]* Yeah but what I'm sayin' is I don't really want you there to console her

LENNY: But . . . Why, Gil? I mean, do you want to see her suffer?

GIL: Not at all. But I even more don't want to see her with you

LENNY: But that's not very fair, is it? I mean, here you don't want her anymore

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GIL: I never said I didn't "WANT" her, Lenny

LENNY: Well, you said you were breaking up

GIL: I said I was thinkin' of breaking up - that the little, dancin' thought had walked my mind! But I mean I didn't realize that automatically gave YOU the green light to pounce? *[Rises, angry.]* All your concern for the what, why, why were you just, ya know, circlin' the area till you could swoop down -like some little galosh-wearin' vulture

LENNY: *[Backing away.]* That's not a very flattering characterization, Gil

GIL: - and . . . and what? just feast on my leftovers?! - and . . . and I mean Allison, no less - Allison of all girls - don't you know how outta your league Allison is?

LENNY: Yes of course, but - but you said to go for it!

GIL: It. IT. Not HER, you [jerk]!

LENNY: *[Summoning up his courage.]* But why not? *[Rises.]* Why not her?

GIL: Because . . . because

LENNY: *[Hitting his stride.]* Because what, Gil, HUH?! All my life I've watched the Leonards of this world lose the Allisons of this world to the Gils of this world and the Gils don't even care! *[He throws saucer against wall.]* I'm sick of it, I tell you! I'm sick, sick, sick! It's men like you who destroy women for the rest of us; abusing and demeaning and rejecting them till they so totally lose their sense of selves they actually believe the REAL men are the men who treat them that way -- when in fact you're not real at all, you're just scared, scared of growing up, scared of yourself, scared that - just like you said in that speech - that one day you're gonna look into her eyes and see the hate because deep down you believe once Allison sees you, once she really sees Gilly for who he is, she'll see THERE'S NOTHING TO SEE!

GIL: Yeah? *[Rises.]* Well- *[Trying to find the right words]* –Shut up, Lenny! Shut up! *[Screams, grabs his collar.]* SHUT UP! *[Silence, GIL lets go.]*

LENNY: I think I've offended you Gil- *[Sits.]* -I'm sorry

GIL: No, don't be sorry, don't be sorry - who wants your sorry, Lenny? Allison's a GIFT, a PRIZE - who loves me! And so that's a VERY scary thing *[Lenny covers his face.]* - I mean, it's alotta

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pressure - alotta - who wants to deal with dissappointin' a girl like that, ya know? ! We're not talkin' some whale beast like Cindy - we're talkin' Allison Kramer! And so even if a part athat - if part awhat you said fear - whatever you said - even if it's something involved with that. . . so what? I mean - what does that prove? That I'm no good? Because I'm - I'm human? That I may be scared of rejection deep down? Alright! So what, ya know? Deep down everybody's scared of rejection! Everybody!

LENNY: *[Puffing up his chest.]* I'm not!

GIL: Yeah? Well that's just cuz you're so used to it

LENNY: Damn straight! Damn straight I am! *[Rises, speaks quietly.]* Take a look at a real man, Gil- a man who's not afraid of rejection, of intimacy, of commitment, the dark - well okay I am a little afraid of the dark - but I'm not afraid of love! Love I embrace unguarded - and I love Allison! I want her, Gil!

GIL: *[Also rises.]* Yeah, well so do I!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Cherie Vogelstein
Book: The Best American Short Plays 1998-99
ISBN: 978-1557834256
Publisher: CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform
Date (Month/Year): May 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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